Burkina Faso's Sovereign Gold Strategy

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Abstract

Since 2022, Burkina Faso′s military government has extended state control over much of the country′s formal gold trade, while leaving its largest foreign-run mines in private hands and staying in the CFA franc it denounces. This paper examines that pattern as Burkina Faso′s Sovereign Gold Strategy: a configuration of policies through which the state extends control over the production, circulation and rents of gold without owning the whole sector. The strategy is defined by the interplay of four properties: protracted counter-insurgency, pragmatic state capitalism, systemic monetary exposure and rhetorical dissonance, the regime′s public denunciation of a currency whose benefits its rhetoric does not acknowledge. Using West African Resources′ audited accounts, the paper estimates what the strategy′s instruments yield and identifies a control–capacity squeeze: a structural vulnerability in which control creates commitments that may outgrow the state′s capacity to finance, operate and secure them. On an exploratory measure against the gold income the fiscal rule leaves free, the squeeze would bind after a fall in the gold price of about a fifth, and sooner with an oil shock or higher war spending. A comparison with Mali and Niger shows that the strategy does not explain why Burkina Faso keeps the franc, though it raises the cost of leaving. The paper then applies the framework to a falling gold price, the turn to Russia and Australian investment, recasting the risk to West African Resources as a gradual transfer of value and an asymmetric exposure to gold rather than nationalisation.

Keywords: gold; resource sovereignty; state capitalism; CFA franc; monetary sovereignty; Burkina Faso; Sahel

1. Introduction

The Sahel′s military governments have broken with France in almost every way but one. Mali, Burkina Faso and Niger expelled French troops, banned French broadcasters and left ECOWAS, yet all three still use the West African CFA franc, a currency pegged to the euro and guaranteed by the French Treasury. Their confederation, the Alliance of Sahel States (AES), has proposed a gold-backed currency, the sira, but it exists only on paper.

Burkina Faso shows the tension most clearly. Its government calls the franc a colonial relic, controls the one resource that could in principle back a currency, and has built a state apparatus around gold: SONASP buys artisanal gold, SOPAMIB runs mines, Raffinor-BF refines, and the treasury takes a rising share of foreign miners' revenue. Yet it has left one of its largest foreign producers, the Australian-listed West African Resources (WAF), in private hands. Recorded output passed 94 tonnes in 2025, over 30 tonnes more than in 2024, mostly because recorded artisanal output rose from 8.1 to about 42 tonnes (Ecofin, 2026a).

This paper examines that pattern as Burkina Faso's Sovereign Gold Strategy, defined by the interplay of four properties: protracted counter-insurgency, pragmatic state capitalism, systemic monetary exposure and rhetorical dissonance. "Strategy" means a consistent pattern whose logic can be read from conduct, not a plan the regime is shown to have designed.

The paper makes three contributions. It distinguishes control from capacity, identifying a control–capacity squeeze in which the commitments created by control may outgrow the state's capacity to meet them, and offers a provisional measure of it: on current commitments, the squeeze would bind after a fall in the gold price of about a fifth. It shows why controlling a resource suited to backing a currency has not produced monetary sovereignty, and tests, and largely rejects, the idea that the strategy explains why the regime keeps the franc. And it applies the framework, using WAF's audited accounts to estimate what the strategy's instruments yield and to read sovereign risk for Australian investors.

The key claims rest on IMF staff reports, WAF's audited accounts and ASX filings, a published decree, and research by ACLED and the International Crisis Group; official Burkinabè figures, available only as ministerial statements reported in the press, are treated as unverified. WAF, the only large operator in Burkina Faso that publishes audited accounts, serves as an auditable proxy for the state's claims on a major private producer, not as a measure of the sector. Currency conversions use approximate 2026 averages of CFAF 560 (IMF, 2026a) and A$1.43 (Pound Sterling Live, 2026) per US dollar for 2026 figures, and about CFAF 580 per dollar for 2025 figures (IMF, 2026a), and ratios to GDP and government revenue use IMF estimates for 2025 of about CFAF 16.1 trillion and CFAF 3.4 trillion respectively (IMF, 2026a; 2026b). The quantitative analysis uses a single Python script with three models, covering mirror trade data, the control–capacity squeeze and the effect of insecurity on WAF's valuation; the code and its assumptions are publicly available (see Data and code availability).

Section 2 defines the strategy and the squeeze, Section 3 sets out the context, and Section 4 examines the four properties. Section 5 considers a falling gold price, including one driven by oil, Section 6 examines the Russian pivot, Section 7 turns to Australian investment, Section 8 examines the paper's causal ambiguities, and Section 9 concludes.

2. Defining the strategy

Burkina Faso's Sovereign Gold Strategy aims to expand effective state control over the production, circulation and rents of gold without ownership of the whole sector. What distinguishes it from simple state ownership or a tax regime is the way four properties specific to Burkina Faso's situation act on one another.

2.1 The four properties

Protracted counter-insurgency creates the pressure for control, limits its reach and, the longer it lasts without decisive gains, threatens the regime's support. Gold finances armed groups, so controlling it becomes security policy, but a state that cannot hold its mining areas must exercise control where it is strong. A state's capacity to decide differs from its capacity to implement decisions across its territory (Mann, 1984), and African states have long struggled to project power beyond their core (Herbst, 2000).

Pragmatic state capitalism supplies the instruments. The state acts as owner, investor and trader rather than only as regulator (Bremmer, 2010), combining the roles of entrepreneur, majority investor and minority investor (Musacchio and Lazzarini, 2014). It extends control along the gold chain without owning every stage, a form of quasi-vertical integration (Blois, 1972) whose choices resemble a make-or-buy calculation (Williamson, 1985): it buys where trade is informal, owns where assets fall to it and taxes where foreign operators are profitable. Its leverage rises once investment is sunk (Vernon, 1971) and when prices are high (Bremmer and Johnston, 2009), and it aims mainly to capture revenue rather than build industry (Wilson, 2015).

Systemic monetary exposure constrains the choice among those instruments. Every instrument depends on the gold price, and inside a currency union the state lacks the authority to issue currency, set policy and manage the exchange rate (Cohen, 1998) that might cushion a fall. Monetary sovereignty has historically served state-building (Helleiner, 2003), but sharing a currency trades it for stability and credit (Mundell, 1961; Alesina and Barro, 2002).

Rhetorical dissonance shapes the political setting. States routinely decouple what they say about sovereignty from what they do (Krasner, 1999), and organisations facing conflicting demands often satisfy one audience with talk and another with action (Brunsson, 1989). In Burkina Faso its core is the absence, in the regime's public rhetoric examined here, of any acknowledgement of the benefits of the currency it denounces: the rhetoric treats the CFA franc as a colonial chain, while the strategy depends on the convertibility, credit and stability the franc provides. The first three properties are structural conditions; the fourth is the political mechanism that lets the regime live with them, and the evidence for it is accordingly more interpretive.

2.2 The interplay

The properties form a system rather than a list. The war makes gold control urgent and pushes it downstream, to purchasing, refining and export control, the instruments that work where the army holds ground; it also underpins the rhetoric, since a regime whose legitimacy rests on defeating the insurgency frames gold control as part of the fight. Those instruments deepen monetary exposure by committing the state to buying, financing and taxing gold whose value it cannot control. That exposure, and the convertibility and credit the instruments depend on, restrain the rhetoric's radical implications, which is why the regime denounces the franc but stays in it. The rhetoric in turn demands visible acts of control, pressing the state into stakes and state enterprises that add to its commitments.

Remove any one property and the strategy changes. Without the war, gold control would be a fiscal choice rather than a security imperative; without pragmatic state capitalism, the state would lack the flexible mix of buying, owning and taxing that lets it match instruments to conditions; without monetary exposure, it would have the exchange rate as a further, if costly, means of absorbing a price fall; and without the dissonance, the regime would have to act on its words or abandon them.

2.3 Why gold

Gold suits the strategy for three reasons. It can be captured from below: much of it is dug by hand and sold informally, so the state can extend its reach by becoming the main official buyer, as post-independence marketing boards did with smallholder crops, extracting revenue and provoking smuggling as they went (Bates, 1981). It is fought over: portable, valuable and often found where the state is weak. And it can be money. Yet control of gold is not monetary sovereignty. The state must acquire gold, retain it rather than sell it, and hold it as an audited reserve in an institution entitled to issue currency against it. Burkina Faso has gone far on the first step; evidence on the second is thin; the institutions for the third do not exist.

2.4 The control–capacity squeeze

The interplay creates a characteristic vulnerability, which the paper calls a *control–capacity squeeze*: the condition in which a state's claims over a resource expand faster than its ability to finance, operate and secure them. Burkina Faso can decree a 15 per cent stake or an export ban; it cannot police every pit, finance every acquisition or run every mine. Unlike ordinary resource dependence, the squeeze arises because control itself generates commitments: acquisitions to pay for, mines to run, counters and convoys to protect, and a buying network to fund. Each property contributes: pragmatic state capitalism creates the commitments, the war adds security obligations while limiting the state's reach, monetary exposure limits the means to finance them, and the rhetoric

makes retreat politically costly. Pragmatic state capitalism is also the main safeguard, since much of its pragmatism consists in avoiding commitments the state cannot meet: taking over only mines whose owners are leaving, negotiating stakes rather than seizing them, and taxing rather than running profitable operators. The squeeze is therefore most likely to surface early where that restraint gives way, in state purchasing at scale. It need not take the form of a state funding crisis: the state can shift costs onto miners and traders through new levies, mandatory dividends or slower payment, displacing the squeeze rather than resolving it. Its signs would be delayed payments or heavier borrowing, lower buying prices or falling collections, operating strain at state mines, and new levies on foreign miners. The paper treats the squeeze as a structural vulnerability rather than a demonstrated constraint: the commitments are observable, but whether they already exceed the state's capacity cannot be established without the accounts of SONASP and SOPAMIB.

The squeeze is a version of an old problem. Like the gap between commitments and power that Lippmann (1943) warned against, or the overstretch Kennedy (1987) traced in great powers, it arises when obligations outrun the means to meet them; here, though, the obligations lie in the state's control of its own territory and economy rather than abroad. Its financial form is overtrading, in which purchases expand faster than the working capital needed to fund them, precisely the risk SONASP's buying network runs, while the state's mines, stakes and purchasing create contingent liabilities that fall on the budget if gold revenue fails (Polackova, 1998).

The squeeze can be provisionally operationalised in several ways, and the concept does not depend on any one of them: a reader who rejects the measure below can still accept the argument above. One exploratory measure, over a twelve-month horizon, is

$$S = (C + B) \div (R - (n - c)Y)$$

where C is the cash costs of exercising control that fall due within the next twelve months (loan service, construction and paid stakes), B any shortfall SONASP cannot cover from its own cash and available credit that would fall to the state, R the state's gold income at a given price, and $(n - c)Y$ the part of that income treated as needed to close the gap between the non-mining deficit n and the WAEMU ceiling c, where Y is GDP; that allocation is a modelling assumption, not a consequence of the rule itself. The ceiling is used not because it is always respected, but because it is the benchmark against which Burkina Faso's regional borrowing and its IMF programme are judged, so the income it leaves free is the most relevant measure of fiscal room; Section 5 shows how much the result depends on it. Alternatives such as total revenue, reserves or borrowing capacity are less apt, since non-gold revenue is already committed, reserves are pooled at the BCEAO and borrowing is governed by the same rule. The measure also captures only the financial dimension of capacity; the capacity to operate and secure what the state controls is not measured, though Section 7.2 estimates what insecurity costs a private

producer. Costless claims such as royalties enter only through *R*. When *S* reaches 1, the modelled costs of control exhaust the gold income the fiscal rule leaves free. That is an accounting threshold rather than an empirically validated point of strain, so the index is best read as continuous, and *B* is unobserved and set to zero where SONASP's accounts suggest no shortfall. It signals the squeeze, not insolvency: the state can still borrow, defer payments, cut other spending or shift costs onto miners. The ratio also has a boundary: if gold income falls to (n − c)Y or below, which on these assumptions happens below about US$2,800 an ounce, the denominator vanishes and the budget breaches the ceiling before any cost of control is counted. A falling price shrinks the denominator while the costs stay fixed, which is why the squeeze tightens in a downturn (Section 5; see Data and code availability).

3. Context

The gold boom made the strategy affordable. On the LBMA PM fix, gold rose from US$1,671.75 an ounce when Traoré took power on 30 September 2022 to a peak of US$5,405 on 29 January 2026, then fell by about a quarter to US$4,001.80 on 25 June and stayed above US$4,000 in October (SD Bullion, 2022; 2026; PriceGold, 2026). At these prices control paid. WAF sold gold at US$4,744 an ounce in the first half of 2026 against all-in sustaining costs (AISC) of US$1,823 (West African Resources, 2026c), and gold revenue helped cut the budget deficit from 5.8 per cent of GDP in 2024 to 1.8 per cent in 2025 (IMF, 2026b).

The forces moving that price lie far from the Sahel. In September 2026, as oil prices driven up by the war involving Iran fed into US inflation, the Federal Reserve raised interest rates for the first time in more than three years (The National, 2026). Higher real rates and a stronger dollar raise the cost of holding gold, and spot gold fell 6.3 per cent that month (State Street, 2026): a fall consistent with that mechanism, though a single month's movement cannot isolate its cause.

The monetary setting adds a motive. None of the AES states issues its own currency: the regional central bank, the BCEAO, sets monetary policy for all eight WAEMU members, and each government funds its war from revenue and regional borrowing under a shared deficit rule. Two of the three have seen that system turned against them. Sanctions in January 2022 froze Malian state assets in regional banks and led Mali to miss bond payments (Reuters, 2022), and Niger's assets were frozen after its 2023 coup until February 2024 (VOA, 2024a). Gold, by contrast, is a store of value a state can hold itself.

Yet the three states have used gold differently. Mali relies on taxing foreign miners; a dispute with Barrick cut Loulo-Gounkoto's output from 22.5 to 5.5 tonnes in 2025 (Mining Weekly, 2026a), its state miner holds closed mines (Ecofin, 2025c), and it has no state buying network comparable to SONASP. Niger took over its one industrial gold mine,

Samira Hill, after output fell to 177 kilograms in 2023 (EWN, 2025). Burkina Faso's scale and output mix help explain the difference: it recorded about 94 of the roughly 145 tonnes the three states reported, about 42 of them artisanal, while Mali's 48.2 tonnes were mostly industrial and foreign-operated, which suits taxation rather than purchase (Mining Weekly, 2026a). The comparison is suggestive only, since reporting systems differ. What matters later is that, whatever their approach to gold, all three states remain in the franc.

4. The four properties of Burkina Faso's Sovereign Gold Strategy

4.1 Protracted counter-insurgency

The strategy is pursued in a long war over territory where much of Burkina Faso's gold lies. The IMF, citing the Global Terrorism Index, ranks the country second only to Pakistan, with about 2.1 million people displaced, and the government aims at full reconquest of its territory only by 2030 (IMF, 2026b). The regime took power in 2022 promising to defeat the insurgency; the war has continued, and in 2024, citing security, it extended its transition by five years and postponed elections (Al Jazeera, 2022; Africanews, 2024). Both of the country's 2022 coups were justified by failures against the insurgency (Al Jazeera, 2022), so the longer the war continues without a decisive improvement in security, the greater the risk that support for the regime erodes. Gold is part of what the war is fought over. Armed groups seize or tax artisanal sites across the central Sahel and smuggle the gold to world markets (International Crisis Group, 2019), a pattern familiar from conflicts in which easily extracted resources finance armed groups and power is organised around resource areas and trading networks (Le Billon, 2001). Gold accounts for 90 per cent of recorded mining-related political violence in the AES states, and JNIM, the main jihadist coalition, taxes local mining and uses some sites as bases (ACLED, 2026).

The war supplies a motive. Traoré presents drawing gold into official channels as a way to cut armed groups off from smuggling revenue (Arise News, 2026), and the government has pledged mining revenue partly to security (North Africa Post, 2025). Whether control reduces insurgent income is unproven: groups that tax miners at the pit can keep doing so whoever buys the gold. The war also limits control. Unable to hold the mining areas, the state concentrates control downstream, at the points gold must pass through to become money: buying counters in army-held towns, the refinery in Ouagadougou, and the export channel that the ban on private exports reserves for the state. Where insurgents hold the resource areas, the state contests the trading networks instead.

4.2 Pragmatic state capitalism

Pragmatic state capitalism is how the strategy integrates vertically along the gold chain, and two moves stand out: an aggressive campaign against the gold black market, and the state's emergence as a gold producer. Around them sit the instruments of the 2024 mining code and the decrees that followed. The code raised the state's free carried interest in every mine from 10 to 15 per cent, gave it a paid subscription right to at least a further 30 per cent, for itself and/or national private investors (Lefaso.net, 2024; Ecofin, 2025e), made a priority dividend to the state mandatory (West African Resources, 2026e) and favoured national suppliers (Mining Weekly, 2025a). A royalty regime introduced in April 2025 raises the rate as the gold price rises (MiningMX, 2026), and SONASP holds purchase agreements with industrial miners (Burkina24, 2024).

Capturing the black market

The campaign against the black market is the core of the strategy. Across Africa, 72 to 80 per cent of artisanal gold goes undeclared, and at least 435 tonnes were smuggled off the continent in 2022, much of it to the United Arab Emirates (SWISSAID, 2024). In February 2024 Burkina Faso suspended export permits for artisanal and semi-mechanised gold and directed holders to SONASP (VOA, 2024b), which buys through counters across the country (IMF, 2026a). Recorded artisanal output rose roughly fivefold, from 8.1 tonnes in 2024 to about 42 tonnes in 2025, and SONASP reported collecting nearly 29 tonnes of artisanal and semi-mechanised gold in the first half of 2026 (APA News, 2026a; Capmad, 2026b), roughly the scale of the 26.7 tonnes industrial mines produced (Capmad, 2026d). The measures are related but not equivalent. Recorded production is a national estimate; SONASP's collections are its own purchases, which some ministry reports state in raw rather than fine weight and count as including gold from mining tailings (29.56 tonnes raw, or 27.08 tonnes fine, by September 2025; Faso Detox, 2025). The comparison with industrial output is therefore provisional.

Two independent sources test these figures. Mirror trade data, which compare what Burkina Faso reports exporting with what importers report receiving, show the United Arab Emirates recording about US$265 million more gold from Burkina Faso than Burkina Faso reported in 2022, and about US$127 million more in 2023: a gap consistent with smuggling, though differences in timing, routing and customs classification can also produce such gaps, and narrowing before the ban. In 2024 the UAE's share of Burkina Faso's officially reported gold exports rose to 35 per cent, from 5 per cent in 2022, while Switzerland's records match Burkina Faso's to within 2 per cent by value (World Bank, 2026; author's calculations). SONASP's 2025 accounts report sales of CFAF 3,281 billion, about 51 tonnes at the year's average price, broadly consistent with its reported purchases of artisanal and industrial gold (Horonya Finance, 2026). The collections are therefore real flows, though whether smuggling has ended cannot be settled until the

UAE reports its 2024 imports. To the extent the rise reflects formalisation, the state has captured a flow that once escaped royalties, foreign-exchange repatriation and official statistics, and the gain expresses all four properties at once: revenue, a blow to insurgent finance, export earnings channelled into the franc system and a visible act of sovereignty.

The figures need caution. The 2026 collections imply, on a simple doubling, an annual rate near 58 tonnes, which could reflect further formalisation, real growth, reclassified semi-mechanised output, sales from old stocks or gold drawn from neighbouring countries; the sources do not distinguish among these. The figures show the reach of state purchasing over formal channels, not reduced smuggling or the state's share of the underlying market. Formalisation also lasts only while selling to the state serves miners better than the alternatives, and efforts to formalise artisanal mining in sub-Saharan Africa have often failed for that reason (Hilson, 2007; Hilson and McQuilken, 2014).

Purchasing is also the strategy's largest gross flow. As a benchmark, 29 tonnes valued at WAF's realised price of US$4,744 an ounce would represent about US$4.4 billion in gross metal value, roughly 15 per cent of 2025 GDP, or about 8 per cent less if the tonnage is raw gold of the roughly 92 per cent fineness implied by the ministry's 2025 figures (author's valuation). SONASP's accounts show how thinly that flow is carried. At the end of 2025 its current assets equalled less than a day of sales, so it buys and sells almost back-to-back and holds little gold exposed to the price; but it earned a net margin of about 0.18 per cent and moved CFAF 3,281 billion of gold on CFAF 8 billion of equity (Horonya Finance, 2026; author's calculations). Its vulnerability is therefore not stockholding but liquidity and margin. Like the marketing boards before it, SONASP wins gold only if its price and speed of payment beat the smugglers', and with a margin this thin it has almost no room to pay more or absorb losses. If its funding tightens, gold drifts back to the black market. How SONASP is financed and how quickly it pays miners remain undisclosed. Purchasing is therefore where the squeeze would likely show first, as a liquidity strain rather than a fiscal one.

Becoming a producer

The second move made the state a gold producer in its own right. Through SOPAMIB it runs Boungou and Wahgnion, transferred in June 2025 after Endeavour Mining's planned sale of them collapsed (Mining Weekly, 2025b), and is restarting Taparko. The state took over assets whose owner was leaving, not mines whose operators wanted to stay. In July 2026 SOPAMIB was authorised to build Bouboulou, the first fully state-owned industrial gold mine, for over CFAF 32 billion (Capmad, 2026c), marking a shift from inheriting mines to building them; its mines run on rented equipment financed by about CFAF 43 billion in regional development bank loans over 2025–26 (Capmad, 2026a). The CFAF 11 billion Raffinor-BF refinery, opened in September 2026, can process 164 tonnes a year and depends on SONASP for supply (EWN, 2026). Refining to high purity is not the hurdle;

acceptance is. Bars trade freely on the global market only from refineries accredited to the London Bullion Market Association's Good Delivery standard, and South Africa's Rand Refinery is the only accredited gold refiner in Africa (Ecofin, 2026e). Until Raffinor-BF is accredited, domestic refining extends control without giving Burkinabè bars the standing a reserve asset would need.

Rent capture

WAF shows how the state extracts value where it does not take ownership. It produced 300,383 ounces, about 9.3 tonnes, in 2025 (West African Resources, 2026d), roughly 18 per cent of industrial output (Capmad, 2026b). High grades underpin its economics: its managing director has put the average resource grade of the M1 South deposit at Sanbrado at about 12 grams per tonne, against 1.5 to 2 grams at typical West African mines (Stockhead, n.d.), and low costs let it bear a rising state take. Its operator has shown no sign of leaving, so by the logic of the Boungou and Wahgnion transfers it is not a candidate for takeover.

The state's claims have grown through several channels. In 2025 WAF recorded A$169.1 million in royalties and production taxes, up from A$59.9 million in 2024, on gold sales of A$1,530.8 million, plus A$240.5 million in income tax expense; the state's carried interest rose to 15 per cent at no cost and its priority dividend became mandatory (West African Resources, 2026e). Royalties at Sanbrado rose from about 8 per cent of revenue in mid-2025 to about 14 per cent in early 2026 (West African Resources, 2026b), and WAF paid a reported A$67.2 million priority dividend in the first half of 2026 (MiningMX, 2026). At Kiaka the state moved towards ownership by negotiation, scaling back a request for a further 35 per cent to 25 per cent, bought for A$175 million, which takes its interest to 40 per cent (West African Resources, 2026a); in July the terms were still being finalised (Mining Weekly, 2026b). Essakane, generally described as the country's largest gold mine, has been treated the same way: IAMGOLD retains 85 per cent, its royalties rose by US$258 to about US$460 an ounce, and it paid the state US$128.3 million in dividends in June 2025 (Ecofin, 2026c; APA News, 2026b).

Measuring the mix

WAF's accounts allow a rough estimate of what each instrument yields, with Essakane, a larger and higher-cost operator, as a cross-check. In 2025 WAF's royalties and production taxes equalled about 11 per cent of its gold sales, and its income tax expense about 16 per cent (West African Resources, 2026e). Applied to industrial output of 51.55 tonnes at the 2025 average LBMA price of US$3,432 an ounce (LBMA, 2026) and about CFAF 580 per dollar (IMF, 2026a), these ratios give roughly CFAF 360 billion in royalties and production taxes and CFAF 530 billion in income tax. Three cases follow. The base case, WAF's full profile, is about CFAF 890 billion. The low case halves the income-tax component, since a low-cost producer pays more tax per ounce than the sector average and tax expense is

not cash received, giving about CFAF 620 billion. A constructed upper scenario substitutes Essakane's royalties of about US$460 an ounce, some 13 per cent of the average price (APA News, 2026b), which would put royalties nearer CFAF 440 billion and the total at about CFAF 970 billion. The resulting range of roughly CFAF 620 to 970 billion, or 4 to 6 per cent of GDP, is a proxy estimate rather than an observed figure. It is of the same order as the IMF's figure of CFAF 573 billion in mining revenue for the first nine months of 2025 (IMF, 2026a), but the measures differ in coverage and timing, and Essakane's royalty figure may include levies WAF reports separately, so the comparison narrows the uncertainty without removing it.

Artisanal gold is larger in volume but uncertain as revenue: the 42 tonnes recorded in 2025 were worth about CFAF 2.7 trillion if treated as fine gold, yet SONASP's accounts show what the state earns from buying it: a net profit of CFAF 5.9 billion and a budget contribution of CFAF 7.2 billion in 2025 (Horonya Finance, 2026). Ownership involves smaller and differently structured commitments: about CFAF 43 billion in loans for state mines (a financing liability), over CFAF 32 billion for Bouboulou (a capital commitment) and about CFAF 70 billion for the Kiaka stake (an acquisition cost), together under 1 per cent of GDP. These are different kinds of quantity and cannot be ranked as interchangeable, but together they describe the strategy's observed fiscal configuration: most measurable gold revenue comes from foreign producers, the largest gross flow runs through state purchasing, and ownership has so far involved limited costs, its significance strategic rather than fiscal. Whether policymakers chose this configuration deliberately cannot be established from the figures (author's calculations throughout).

The configuration captures value while avoiding the capital, operating and security risks of running mines. The cost of compensation, limited technical capacity, the risk of deterring investors and financing under the franc's deficit rule help explain why this configuration is observed, though they are not evidence that the regime deliberately optimised the mix; and unlike the state capitalisms of China or the Gulf, Burkina Faso has no state banks or national central bank to fund its enterprises.

4.3 Systemic monetary exposure

The strategy rests on a price the state cannot control, and the CFA franc system determines how a fall must be absorbed. Gold made up nearly 90 per cent of exports in 2025, and without mining revenue the 2025 budget deficit of 1.8 per cent of GDP would have been 6.0 per cent (IMF, 2026b). Every instrument deepens the exposure: royalties and dividends fall with the price, gold SONASP holds can lose value before it is sold, and the largest commitments, from the Kiaka purchase to the state-mine loans, were incurred during the boom, some through the price peak. The euro peg adds a further channel: gold is priced in dollars while the franc is fixed at CFAF 655.957 to the euro, so a stronger euro lowers the franc value of every ounce sold.

The franc, read both as a useful restraint (Stasavage, 2003) and as a neocolonial arrangement (Taylor, 2019; Pigeaud and Sylla, 2021), is first a support for the strategy. A stable, convertible currency helps SONASP compete with smugglers and reassures foreign miners; the regional development bank finances state mines; Burkina Faso raised about CFAF 1,189 billion on the regional securities market in 2025 (IMF, 2026b); and the union's pooled reserves, about US$33 billion in October 2025 (Ecofin, 2025d), cushion falls in gold earnings. What it does not provide is national monetary policy. The 2019 reform ended the requirement to deposit half the BCEAO's reserves with the French Treasury but kept the euro parity and France's guarantee (Fasken, 2020), so a shock specific to Burkina Faso must be absorbed through the budget and borrowing, and, as Mali and Niger found, access to the union's resources can be cut off.

Nor has control of gold become monetary sovereignty. The 2025 balance-of-payments surplus of about CFAF 856 billion is consistent with the rise in Burkina Faso's net foreign assets at the BCEAO reported by the IMF (IMF, 2026b), although the two are not identical measures: a claim on the union's pooled reserves, fed by export earnings that must be repatriated through local banks (Ecofin, 2025a), rather than gold held by Burkina Faso itself. The state's share arrives as cash; the national gold reserve announced in 2025 remains undisclosed in size and location (Mining Weekly, 2025a); and the sovereign mining fund created in May 2026, the Fonds souverain minier d'investissements du Burkina Faso (FSMIB), known as Siniyan-Sigui, is a cash account for investment (Ecofin, 2026b). Absence of disclosure does not prove that no gold is held, only that no operational monetary arrangement has been shown. A credible gold-backed currency, national or shared, would also face the pressure on wartime governments to print money (Kydland and Prescott, 1977; Barro and Gordon, 1983), which has often ended gold backing (Eichengreen, 1992), while reserves held abroad, as the BCEAO holds most of its gold (Ecofin, 2025b), would undercut the promise of sovereignty. Devaluation would raise the local value of gold receipts but make imports dearer in a country where fuel and fertiliser were 35 per cent of imports in 2025 (IMF, 2026b). For a gold-dependent country at war, the franc's convertibility and credit may be worth more than the freedom to adjust.

4.4 Rhetorical dissonance

The regime frames gold control as the recovery of national wealth from colonial domination. Traoré said in September 2025 that "the government's approach is to exploit our gold ourselves" (Ecofin, 2025e); the refinery was presented as keeping mining wealth at home (Arise News, 2026); and in early 2024 he suggested leaving the franc, promising to "break all ties that keep us in slavery" (Ecofin, 2024). The conduct is more measured, and his own words anticipate it: in the same broadcast he said the state would "gradually take control or co-exploit with companies already operating here" (Ecofin, 2025e). The

request for an extra 35 per cent of Kiaka became a negotiated 25 per cent, and more than two years after promising to break the ties of "slavery", Burkina Faso's finance minister chairs the monetary union's council of ministers (IMF, 2026b).

The sharpest gap concerns the franc itself. In the statements examined here, the regime denounces it as a colonial relic without acknowledging what it provides, and the strategy depends on exactly those benefits: convertibility for SONASP and foreign producers, regional credit for state mines and the budget, and the stability of pooled reserves and low inflation (Section 4.3). Admitting any of this would concede that the colonial relic serves the sovereign project.

The contrast is observable; what follows interprets its function. Read this way, the gap may be an asset to the strategy, because talk and conduct address different audiences. The rhetoric is aimed at home, where it plausibly helps secure support for a military government that has postponed elections (Section 4.1). That support is tied to the war the regime promised to win, and anti-colonial rhetoric presents gold control both as recovering national wealth and as cutting armed groups off from revenue. Because a long war without decisive gains threatens that support (Section 4.1), the regime may rely more on gold control, where it can show results, in place of victories it cannot claim on the battlefield. It may also let negotiated compromise with foreign capital read at home as sovereignty, and channel anti-colonial demands into gold, where the state can deliver visible results, rather than into a costly exit from the franc. The conduct is aimed at the miners, lenders, IMF and BCEAO on which the strategy depends, and on that record it has kept investment, credit and convertibility. The audiences are not fully separate, however. Financial markets also hear the talk aimed at home, so the dissonance that sustains support domestically may raise the strategy's cost of capital abroad by leading investors to overstate the risk of nationalisation (Section 7.4). That is the trade-off the dissonance carries. That the dissonance serves the strategy does not show it was designed to.

The franc: an AES test

Does the strategy explain why Burkina Faso keeps the franc? If it did, states with different approaches to gold should choose differently. They do not: Mali and Niger use gold differently, have had their assets in the regional system frozen, and still remain (Section 3). The comparison is not controlled, since the cases also differ in sanctions exposure, production structure and political chronology, but it is enough to reject gold strategy as a sufficient or dominant explanation; the general cost of exit for small, landlocked states at war explains more. A narrower claim survives. Burkina Faso's version, centred on large-scale purchasing, depends unusually on what the franc provides, so it raises the cost of leaving without causing the decision to stay.

The sira

The AES's answer to the franc remains on paper. As of September 2026 there was no confederal central bank, currency or launch date (Rio Times, 2026), Mali had denied that a launch was imminent (Currency News, 2026), and even sympathetic Burkinabè economists set an independent central bank and a ban on monetary financing as preconditions (Ouédraogo, 2026). The obstacles are structural. The credibility problems of Section 4.3 apply with more force to a currency issued by three governments at war, in a weak union of poor, landlocked states exposed to the same shocks (Mundell, 1961; Alesina and Barro, 2002), and leaving the franc would mean dividing the BCEAO's pooled reserves. Burkina Faso's two-thirds share of AES gold sharpens the problem: a gold-backed sira would rest largely on its reserves, inviting partners to borrow against gold they did not produce, prompting Burkina Faso to demand proportionate control, and exposing the whole union to its gold-price and security risks. The region has tried monetary independence before: Mali left the franc zone in 1962 and rejoined in 1984 (Direction générale du Trésor, n.d.). For Burkina Faso, which would bear most of its cost, the sira is valuable to promise and costly to deliver, which makes it the clearest illustration of rhetorical dissonance.

5. A falling gold price

The four properties meet in a single scenario: a sustained fall in the gold price, which is not hypothetical after the falls of 2026 (Section 3). The budget would be hit first. The gap between the overall and non-mining deficits shows how much the budget relies on gold (Section 4.3), and the IMF has urged the government to save in good years (IMF, 2026b). A long fall would reopen much of that gap; the sovereign mining fund, which receives only revenue above a reference price, would offer little cushion; and, unable to devalue, the state would have to borrow, tax or cut under the union's deficit limit while security spending stayed high.

Commitments would not shrink with income. The Kiaka payment, the state-mine loans and the working capital tied up in purchasing would remain, and SONASP would be most exposed: it would face losses on gold already bought, and any cut in its price or delay in payment would push gold back to smugglers. WAF shows the mechanism. Its margin over AISC was about US$2,921 an ounce in the first half of 2026 (West African Resources, 2026c). On unchanged costs, a fall to US$4,000 would cut revenue per ounce by about 16 per cent and the margin by about 25 per cent; a fall to US$3,500, by 26 and 43 per cent; and a fall to US$3,000, a level gold first reached in March 2025 (Mining.com, 2025), by 37 and 60 per cent (author's calculations). The state's claims would fall faster still, since the royalty rate falls with the price and income tax and dividends with profits: its fiscal exposure is highly sensitive to the price. And the cheaper WAF became, the less the state could afford to buy it, while the Kiaka stake priced in a boom would look expensive.

The squeeze index of Section 2.4 puts numbers on this. At October's price of about US$4,000 an ounce it stands at about 0.4: the bills of control absorb around two-fifths of the gold income the fiscal rule leaves free. It reaches 1 after a fall of about a fifth, to roughly US$3,200, with a range of 16 to 30 per cent across assumptions about loan service, the timing of the Kiaka payment and the sensitivity of gold income to the price (author's calculations). The result depends most on whether the deficit ceiling is enforced. If the government tolerated a deficit of 4 per cent of GDP, the squeeze would bind only after a fall of 37 to 52 per cent, and the 2024 deficit of 5.8 per cent suggests the ceiling has not always bound. The war matters almost as much as the price: if security spending widened the non-mining deficit by half a point of GDP, the squeeze would bind after a fall of only 9 per cent, and by a full point it would bind with no fall at all. The exchange rate matters too, since a euro 10 per cent stronger against the dollar would cut the breakeven fall to 11 per cent, and one 10 per cent weaker would raise it to 27. Assumptions about SONASP's financing, by contrast, barely move the result: at the holding periods its accounts imply, the breakeven fall stays between 16 and 19 per cent, so purchasing threatens the strategy through lost gold rather than through the budget (author's calculations).

This is the control–capacity squeeze under pressure: the security imperative and the rhetoric would still favour control while the revenue funding it fell. The regime might raise levies, negotiate further equity, delay acquisitions or take over assets whose owners wished to leave; Section 7.3 sets out which moves become likely. A downturn could also bind Burkina Faso more tightly to the franc's reserves and credit, though the politics of a crisis could push the other way.

5.1 The oil-driven case

The most adverse version is one driven by oil. By September 2026, with the war involving Iran in its seventh month, oil had again topped US$100 a barrel (The National, 2026), as attacks on tankers in the Strait of Hormuz and the closure of Saudi Arabia's East–West pipeline disrupted supply (Reuters, 2026). Oil's main effect on Burkina Faso runs through the gold price, but only conditionally: inflation alone tends to support gold, which falls when central banks push real interest rates up, as the Federal Reserve did in September, and rises when they do not, as in the oil shocks of the 1970s.

What makes the oil-driven case worse than any other fall is that costs rise as revenue falls. Fuel and fertiliser were 35 per cent of imports in 2025 (IMF, 2026b). The state spent nearly CFAF 60 billion on fuel subsidies early in 2026, about 0.4 per cent of GDP, and in August raised the price of diesel for the first time in four years (Benin Web TV, 2026), while inflation across the union rose from −0.2 per cent in the first quarter to 1.7 per cent in August, mainly because of oil (Financial Afrik, 2026; Ecofin, 2026d). The result is a terms-of-trade squeeze of a kind commodity-dependent African economies know well (Deaton, 1999), with subsidies adding a commitment that grows as gold revenue weakens and a

BCEAO that left its rates unchanged in September (Financial Afrik, 2026). Counting fuel subsidies at their early-2026 rate alongside the bills of control raises the squeeze index to about 0.8 at today′s price, so that it would bind after a fall of only 1 to 14 per cent, to between about US$3,450 and US$3,950 (author′s calculations). The peg offers only partial relief: if gold fell 15 per cent while the dollar strengthened 5 per cent, the stronger dollar would lower the index from about 1.7 to 1.3, but the squeeze would still bind. It is an adverse scenario rather than an inevitable one, but if escalation and monetary tightening continue, it is the one the strategy is least equipped to absorb.

6. The Russian pivot

Burkina Faso′s break with France has been accompanied by a turn to Russia, but Russia′s role in the strategy should not be overstated. The strategy′s drivers are domestic, and the new gold licences granted to Russian capital are modest: the Niou mine is expected to yield about 2.5 tonnes a year (AFP, 2024), against national output of about 94 tonnes. The turn is best read as a patron–client pact between two personalised regimes. Within three months of the 2022 coup the prime minister visited Russia, in July 2023 Traoré met Putin in St Petersburg (Kremlin, 2023), and Africa Corps, the state-controlled successor to the Wagner network, arrived later that year (Small Wars Journal, 2026). In personalised regimes, decisions are concentrated in the ruler and a small circle (Geddes, Wright and Frantz, 2018), so alliances run through rulers rather than institutions. Traoré gains protection and a global stage; Putin, isolated after the invasion of Ukraine, gains allies at low cost and openings in a model that has blended security support with extraction deals (Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, 2026).

Four kinds of support need distinguishing. The pact provides regime protection, as the Sahel juntas have used Russian forces to guard against challengers (Small Wars Journal, 2026), and political legitimation, as Russian media amplify their anti-French narratives (Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, 2026). Territorial security is doubtful: Africa Corps has not improved security in contested areas (ADF, 2026). On money, Russia provides no substitute for the franc′s convertibility, regional credit or pooled reserves, whatever other assistance it may offer. It has become the regime′s main security partner while playing no part in the monetary system on which the strategy depends, which deepens the dissonance of Section 4.4. In gold it offers an outside option rather than a new direction. Nordgold, a Russian miner under US sanctions, received the Yimiougou and Niou permits (Mining Weekly, 2023; AFP, 2024), but the mines minister denied any national preference (Mining Weekly, 2023); Russian ownership did not protect Taparko, which Nordgold shut in 2022 (VOA, 2023) and SOPAMIB is restarting; and Burkina Faso built its own refinery rather than feed the plant Mali is building with Russia′s Yadran Group (BBC, 2025). The pact is also opaque, since what Burkina Faso pays for Russian security is undisclosed (Mining Weekly, 2023), and fragile: personalised alliances last only

as long as their rulers, and a small client risks abandonment if its patron's priorities shift (Snyder, 1984). For investors, personalisation means that moves up the escalation ladder (Section 7.3) can come suddenly.

7. Australian investment

For the foreign capital on the ground, the framework becomes a way of reading sovereign risk, and Australian capital is heavily exposed to that risk. Australian mining companies are collectively the largest private investors in both Burkina Faso and Mali, and Australian-headquartered or ASX-listed minerals companies had invested about $60 billion in 234 projects across Africa by 2023 (Satchwell, 2024). That investment is tangible: mines, plants, contractors and employees whose sunk capital cannot leave, which is why host states gain bargaining power once investment is made (Vernon, 1971), and whose people carry risks no portfolio does, as the 2019 attack that killed 19 employees of the Australian contractor Perenti showed (Mining Magazine, 2019). This section is not investment advice.

7.1 Three Australian experiences

Three cases show that risk depends less on nationality than on where an asset sits in the strategy. WAF, a profitable producer whose operator wants to stay, has faced rising claims but not seizure (Section 4.2). Sarama Resources, listed on the ASX and TSX-V, held an undeveloped asset: in August 2023 its Tankoro 2 exploration permit was rejected nearly two years after being granted, and the minister then told a Perth mining conference the permit was available for purchase (Sarama Resources, 2024); Sarama is now claiming US$242 million in international arbitration (Sarama Resources, 2025). In Mali, showing the alternative path, the government detained the chief executive of Perth-based Resolute Mining during tax talks in November 2024 and secured a US$160 million settlement (Mining Weekly, 2024), and Resolute's shares fell by more than 40 per cent (AAP, 2024). The pattern is clear: producing operators that stay face a rising state share, undeveloped permits can be withdrawn, and assets whose owners leave pass to the state.

7.2 WAF as an exposure to gold

Investors hold a stock like WAF mainly for alignment with the gold price, and WAF makes that alignment unusually direct. It is unhedged, selling at prevailing prices (West African Resources, 2026b), and its largely fixed costs give it leverage, as the illustration in Section 5 shows. Research on gold-mining equities confirms the pattern: in Tufano's (1998) study, the average North American producer's shares moved about 2 per cent for each 1 per cent change in the gold price, with exposure lower for firms that hedge and higher for those with more leverage. Both WAF's mines are in Burkina Faso (West African Resources,

2026e), so it is a particularly direct ASX-listed exposure to Burkina Faso's gold sector: holding it means holding unhedged, geared gold and Burkina Faso together. The strategy weakens that alignment in both directions.

On the upside, the state shares the gains. Royalties rise with the price, from about 8 to 14 per cent of Sanbrado's revenue as gold climbed, and the priority dividend takes a share of profits. For an unhedged producer, the progressive royalty is the main thing standing between shareholders and the full spot price: part of the upside a hedge would have sold to a bank has been claimed by the state. The same feature gives company and state correlated but asymmetric exposures to the gold price: WAF bears sales, costs and margins, while the state receives fiscal revenue and carries security, spending and import obligations. The correlation may help explain why relations have been negotiated rather than confrontational.

On the downside, the alignment becomes a shared vulnerability. A sustained fall would cut the state's revenue faster than WAF's and raise its incentive to extract more just as margins narrowed: in credit-market terms, wrong-way risk. A hedge book might cushion a company in exactly that scenario, though how much would depend on its structure and on the form any intervention took. Unhedged, WAF relies instead on its balance sheet, A$847 million in cash and A$213 million of bullion at the end of March 2026 (West African Resources, 2026b), a buffer that cuts both ways: Resolute's initial US$80 million payment to Mali came from its cash reserves (Mining Weekly, 2024). The result is an asymmetric exposure to gold, with the upside shared with the state and the downside compounded by the state's own dependence on the same price.

Insecurity adds a second exposure. A Monte Carlo valuation of WAF's attributable cash flows, with insecurity modelled as lost production, restart costs and higher security spending rather than as a discount-rate premium, puts the expected loss at about 6 per cent of the mines' value under current conditions, equivalent to adding about one percentage point to the discount rate. WAF's south-central mines have reported no security incidents, so the base case assumes a 2 per cent annual chance of a major suspension per mine. At the national rate of security closures, about 6 per cent a year after 5 to 6 of 17 industrial mines shut in 2021–22 (Mines Actu, 2022; allAfrica, 2023), the loss rises to about 16 per cent, and at the 2022 peak to about 28 per cent. Whether the conflict spreads south is therefore the decisive variable, and the risk is skewed: in one simulation in twenty the loss exceeds 30 per cent (author's calculations). Because the hazards are calibrated from a few documented closures rather than event-level data, these figures indicate orders of magnitude, not estimates. The model also treats each mine's risk as independent, though a conflict spreading south could hit both at once and fatten the tail; the discount rate matters little, since at 8 per cent rather than 5 the base-case loss is still about 6 per cent.

7.3 Nationalisation risk as an escalation ladder

Nationalisation risk is better framed as an escalation ladder than as a single event, in Kahn's (1965) sense of a sequence of rungs on which each move is also a bargaining signal. Fiscal measures sit at the bottom; free equity and paid minority stakes above them; permit withdrawal and coercive renegotiation under temporary state control higher still; and permanent takeover at the top. WAF has so far been moved up the lower rungs only. Cumulatively these transfer value to the state through measures none of which takes the asset, which in economic terms resembles what investment law calls creeping or indirect expropriation (Dolzer and Schreuer, 2012), though whether any measure meets that legal standard depends on the applicable treaty, the measure's effects and the investor's rights.

Even the upper rungs have been used as leverage. Mali seized about three tonnes of gold from Barrick's Loulo-Gounkoto complex and placed it under provisional administration in June 2025 (MiningMX, 2025; Canadian Press, 2025), yet the November settlement returned control to Barrick, which withdrew its arbitration claims (Barrick, 2025). In Burkina Faso, the legal limit on state participation is unclear. Beyond its 15 per cent free carried interest, the code gives the state a paid right to subscribe at least a further 30 per cent, for itself and/or national private investors (Lefaso.net, 2024), and the implementing decree has been reported as allowing the state and local investors together up to 45 per cent (Ecofin, 2025f); at Kiaka the state will reach 40 per cent. Whether the state could take a majority on its own will remain uncertain until the promulgated texts are examined. What is clear is that any further stake must be paid for, and that cost is the more immediate constraint. Outright takeover of WAF is unlikely while rent capture delivers a rising share of its cash flows, SOPAMIB is stretched across four mines, compensation would have to be financed under the deficit rule and seizure would deter the investment the strategy depends on.

The risk would rise if WAF tried to exit, as the Boungou and Wahgnion transfers show; if disputes over taxes or permits escalated, as in Mali; or, most consequentially, if the gold price fell. Even then the state would most likely climb the middle rungs, through new levies, pressure over the Kiaka payment and reallocation of idle permits, because a downturn erodes the capital and capacity a takeover requires; the wrong-way risk of Section 7.2 would materialise as a climb up the middle of the ladder, not a leap to the top. The squeeze index gives a sense of its scale: if the state closed the gap entirely by taking more from foreign producers, a 25 per cent fall in gold would require about CFAF 50 billion more a year, roughly 1.7 per cent of industrial gold sales, and a 30 per cent fall about CFAF 90 billion, or 3.4 per cent (author's calculations). Treaty protection matters if escalation occurs, and depends on an investor's holding structure: Sarama's claim rests on the Canada–Burkina Faso bilateral investment treaty (Sarama Resources, 2025).

7.4 Is the risk mispriced?

The pattern suggests a hypothesis that follows from rhetorical dissonance. Investors hear both the rhetoric and the conduct and must decide which to price. If they weight the rhetoric, they may price ASX-listed producers in Burkina Faso as though the strategy threatened foreign ownership itself, when its conduct favours retaining foreign capital while taking more from it. The dissonance would then create a predictable wedge between perceived and actual sovereign risk. Resolute's experience shows how sharply investors react to coercion in the Sahel. Trailing multiples cannot test it: in early October 2026, WAF's market capitalisation of about A$4.0 billion was roughly six times trailing earnings and under three times trailing EBITDA (Kalkine Media, 2026; StockAnalysis, 2026). But such multiples are also what one would expect if investors were pricing earnings near a cyclical peak, so they are not evidence of mispricing. The security model adds only a rough cross-check, since its hazards are assumptions calibrated from a handful of closures: on those assumptions, a country risk premium of 5 to 6 percentage points, common for high-risk jurisdictions, corresponds to insecurity near the 2022 peak, above what WAF's own record suggests (Section 7.2), and applying such a premium on top of modelled losses would count the risk twice; a proper test would compare WAF's valuation with ASX producers in lower-risk jurisdictions or study its share-price response to Burkinabè decrees. If the hypothesis holds, the risk lies less in confiscation than in a gradual transfer of value and an asymmetric exposure to gold, both possibly underpriced because they are undramatic. The indicators most worth watching are delays to the Kiaka payment, new levies on foreign miners, further permit withdrawals, falling SONASP collections, heavier regional borrowing and compliance with the IMF's transparency deadlines.

8. Causal ambiguities

The framework specifies causal relations among the four properties, but specifying a mechanism is not identifying it. The paper proceeds by process tracing and structured comparison (George and Bennett, 2005; Bennett and Checkel, 2015), and its claims differ in strength. Descriptive claims about the state's instruments and its claims on WAF rest on primary documents and audited accounts. Interpretive claims, such as the function of rhetorical dissonance, are inferences from conduct. Causal claims about the links between the properties are supported by consistent evidence but not isolated from alternatives. The strongest causal finding is negative: because Mali and Niger keep the franc despite different gold strategies, gold strategy cannot be the main reason Burkina Faso stays.

Three sources of ambiguity stand out. The properties reinforce one another in loops, each partly cause and partly effect, and with all four present in a single country there is no variation to observe; the counterfactuals of Section 2.2 are reasoned rather than observed. The gold boom confounds the strategy′s apparent success, since a rising state take and a narrowing deficit cannot be fully separated from what high prices would have delivered anyway. And measurement is weak: official figures are unverified, recorded artisanal output may not reflect real change, the effect of gold control on insurgent revenue is unmeasured, and motives are inferred rather than documented.

Each causal link nonetheless implies something observable. If the war pushes control downstream, SONASP′s collections should track the army′s hold on territory, which could be tested against ACLED′s records of violence. If monetary exposure restrains the rhetoric, talk of leaving the franc should cool as dependence on regional credit grows, and the record is consistent with this: the 2024 exit talk gave way to chairing the union′s council of ministers and an IMF programme tied to its rules. If the rhetoric drives commitments, visible acts of control should cluster around moments of political pressure. And if markets misprice the strategy, WAF′s shares should react more to rhetorical events than to fiscal ones.

The most serious rival explanation is a revenue-maximising state exploiting a boom (Bremmer and Johnston, 2009). It accounts for the rising take from foreign miners but not for the concentration of control downstream, the scale of state purchasing or the decision to stay in a currency the regime denounces. IMF conditionality explains the transparency commitments but not an export ban or a state buying monopoly; Russian influence is limited by its small footprint in gold (Section 6); and regime survival explains the rhetoric and the security partnership but not the mix of instruments. The ambiguities define a research agenda rather than undermine the argument. The most useful next step is comparative: Ghana has reformed the purchasing of artisanal gold but issues its own currency (Ecofin, 2026a), so a comparison would isolate the effect of systemic monetary exposure.

9. Conclusion

Burkina Faso′s Sovereign Gold Strategy has substantially expanded state control over the formal gold trade since 2022 without transforming that control into monetary sovereignty. Its character lies in the interaction of protracted counter-insurgency, pragmatic state capitalism, systemic monetary exposure and rhetorical dissonance, which together have let the state increase control without wholesale ownership. In the current configuration, rent capture from foreign producers supplies most of its measurable revenue, artisanal

purchasing carries its largest gross flow, and ownership has so far cost comparatively little while making the state a producer. Russia has become the regime's main security partner, but not a substitute for the monetary system on which the strategy depends.

Three broader points follow. Resource sovereignty is better understood as control than as ownership. Controlling a resource suited to money does not by itself produce monetary sovereignty. And resource sovereignty can deepen a state's practical dependence on a shared currency: the strategy does not explain why Burkina Faso stays in the franc, but its reliance on large-scale purchasing makes leaving more costly.

The central vulnerability is the control–capacity squeeze. On the paper's provisional measure against the gold income the fiscal rule leaves free, the costs of control would exhaust it after a fall in the gold price of about a fifth, after a fall of only a few per cent in an oil shock, and with no fall at all if war spending widened the non-mining deficit by a point of GDP. In state purchasing it would show first as a liquidity strain, as SONASP's thin margin left gold to drift back to smugglers. Disclosure of the national gold reserve, the IMF's deadlines for auditing mining permits and publishing mining ownership by the end of 2026 (IMF, 2026b), and any plan for an AES central bank would test the argument. For Australian investors, the main risk lies less in nationalisation than in a gradual transfer of value and an asymmetric exposure to gold. Markets may nonetheless price the rhetoric rather than the conduct, so the dissonance that sustains the strategy at home may cause its risks to be misread abroad. Above all, the arrangement has not yet faced a long fall in the gold price, which will be its hardest test.

Data and code availability

All figures computed in this paper are reproduced by a single Python script hosted at github.com/Joe-Dusevic/Burkina-Faso-s-Sovereign-Gold-Strategy. It has three parts. The first compares Burkina Faso's reported gold exports with what Switzerland and the UAE report importing, 2022–2024 (Section 4.2). The second calculates the control–capacity squeeze index and every sensitivity reported in Sections 2.4, 5 and 7.3. The third is a Monte Carlo valuation of West African Resources' Burkinabè mines under different security scenarios (Section 7.2). The script documents its sources and assumptions.

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